ruled by other European countries, such as the Portuguese colonies of Goa, Daman and Diu, and the French colony of Pondicherry (now Puducherry). All of these had to somehow be knitted together into a nation.

India's political shape has continued to shift and change after 1947. Indians have always been a heterogeneous group, speaking hundreds of different languages, belonging to a vast number of communities, castes, tribes and faiths, and following a bewildering diversity of customs, traditions and practices. Different groups and communities fought to be seen and heard in the new nation, with language, culture, religion and customs becoming flashpoints for conflict. This led to power struggles between the state and its people. In some cases, these conflicts have continued to the present day.

In this section, you will read about a few individuals whose actions impacted the very shape of the Indian nation—from those who tried to glue the different pieces of British and princely India together into a unified country, to those who believed, for a time, that some of those pieces would be better apart.